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MEDAL HOPE:
Champia's
performance has
been very consistent

AFTER THE DISAPPOINTMENTS OF THE ATHENS OLYMPICS, THE INDIANS ARE DETERMINED TO COMPETE LIKE TRUE CONTENDERS, NOT MERE PARTICIPANTS, IN 2008.

Kumari and the promising Chakravala Soru fall by the wayside. Similarly, in the men's category, illustrious archers like Tarundeep Rai, Jayanta Talukdar and Rahul Banerjee failed to qualify, leaving Mangal Singh Champia, a gifted 24-year-old from a Jharkhand village, as the only Indian man standing in Beijing.

At Salt Lake, the Korean, called Lee Wang Woo, who has groomed eight Olympic gold medallists, says Champia is India's best bet. It is a curious combination: the crack Korean coach and his eager-to-absorb-all trainees, communicating and sharing through an interpreter. Woo says, "They are all good archers. It'll be very challenging at the Olympics. If Champia can withstand that he has a great chance of winning a medal."

Woo's faith is a result of the Jharkhand archer's steady performances. A bronze medal at the 2006 Doha Asian Games was followed by a bronze at the cut-throat 2007 Asian Championships which helped him win qualification for Beijing. He also played a key role in the Indian men's team that snatched Asian gold from Malaysia.

Both Mukherjee and Woo believe that Champia is now at his peak. The rustic archer could hardly have imagined that the rudimentary bow-and-arrow of his boyhood would turn into the sophisticated piece of equipment that today rests in his hands like a metal feather. From Ichakuti village to Beijing is a great leap—of faith and of dream—but the medal, Champia knows, is only as far away as that elusive target he must nail.

In contrast to Champia's progress, Dola, somehow, has not been able to live up to her own performance after the 2007 World Cup Final win. By her own admission, she is not shooting as well as she would have wanted to. "I need to improve before the Olympics," the veteran says, her eyes burning. She found herself at the centre of a selection row when Athens Olympian Reena Kumari squarely accused the AAI of favouring Dola after she was omitted from the Beijing squad.

Dola's teammates have had quieter Olympic preludes. Bombayla is the silent workhorse of the team. Consistent performances in the past one year have earned her the Olympic ticket. The Manipuri archer made the qualification for Beijing with a high quality performance at the World